PROPOSAL · 13 OCTOBER 2026 · SOHO SQUARE GARDENS, W1D 3QH

Blackout

Variant B · a perfume museum beneath Soho Square

Below the lawn there is a 300 m^2 machine hall: a 1928 DC converter substation that became a Blitz shelter, sealed since about 2015. This proposal turns it into a small, hosted perfume museum with a London flagship for Tiziana Terenzi. This page sets out one of four design directions, with its floor plan and long section.



SOHO SQUARE GARDENS · 1132

FLOOR

297 m²

3,200 sq ft, 2015 particulars

PLAN

30 × 10 m

estimate, east–west

DEPTH

3.5–4.5 m

below the lawn, estimate

BUILT

1928

substation, WWII shelter

STAIRS

2

west hatch + Grade II hut

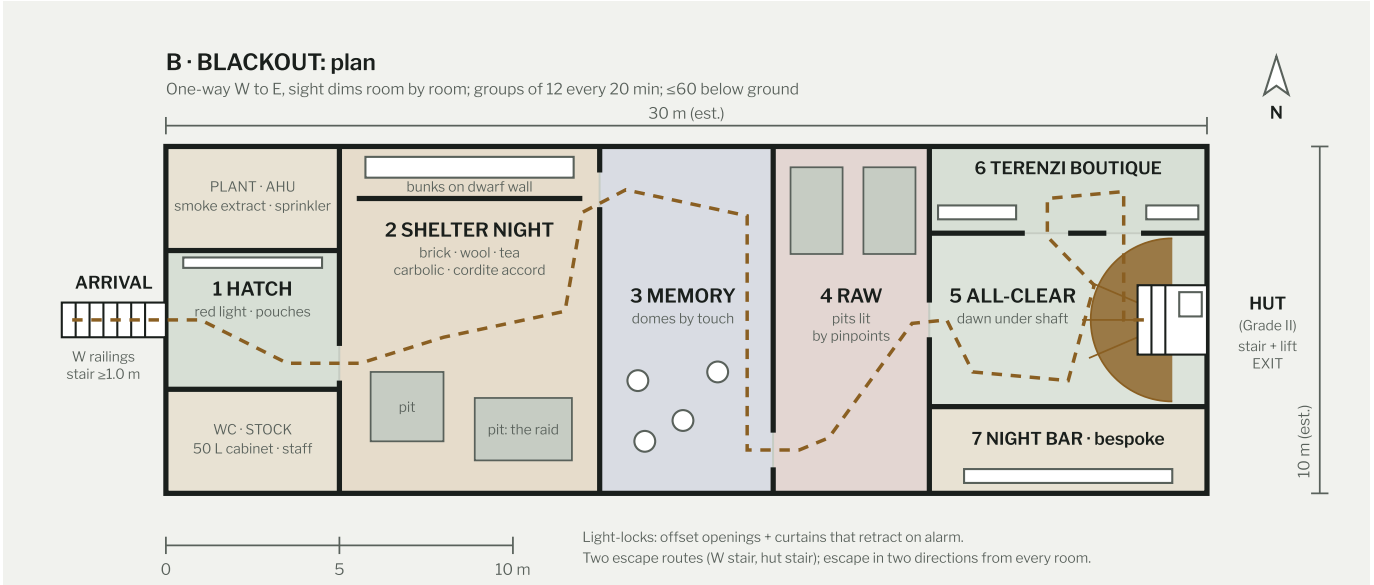
VISITORS

60–70

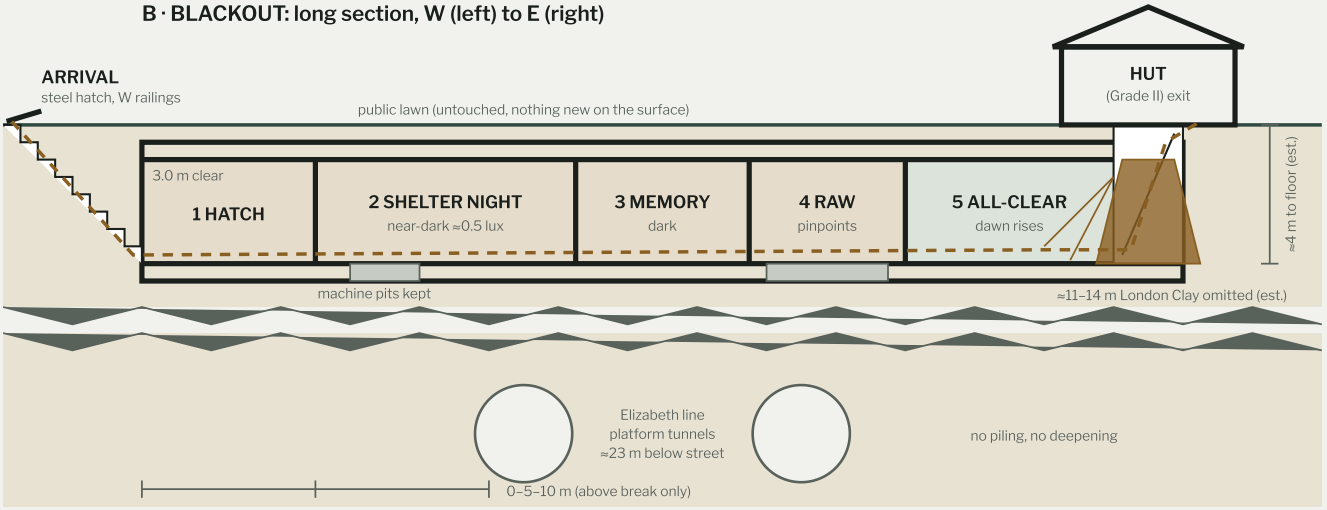
at once, both stairs rebuilt

B Blackout

Leave your phone at the hatch, go down into the dark, and let your nose see you through to the all-clear.



Floor plan, 1:200 at 20 px/m. 30 × 10 m hall, about 297 m^2. West stair = arrival, hut stair = second exit.



Long section, west to east. Depths are estimates until measured.

The idea

On a raid night in 1940–41, Londoners in this room could barely see. They knew the night by smell: wet brick, damp wool, stewed tea, carbolic soap, and the smoke drifting down the stair. BLACKOUT rebuilds that night as a 55-minute sensory journey for groups of 12. Phones are sealed at the hatch. Light falls room by room until sight is nearly gone and smell takes over. The route runs one way, west

to east, from the 1940s shelter, to what people remembered and missed, to the rare raw materials of perfumery, each found by touch in the old machine pits. It ends under the hut shaft with the all-clear: the siren's steady note, a slow dawn falling down the shaft, and a Tiziana Terenzi fragrance released like first light. You come up through the Grade II hut into the square. The earlier plan was a hosted museum with a nocturne; this variant makes the darkness itself the exhibit.

The visit, room by room

A new group of 12 enters every 20 minutes, so about three groups are underground at once (36 visitors plus up to 5 staff and about 10 people browsing the boutique, kept at or under 60). Each dark room is used for no more than 14 of every 20 minutes, which leaves at least 6 minutes for a fresh-air purge before the next group.

1. Hatch (light-lock), 6 min. You come down the rebuilt west stair into a small room lit only in deep red. Phones go into lockable pouches that you keep (Yondr-type; they open at the end). A host in a warden's coat gives a two-minute briefing: what to do if you want to leave (raise the glow-pebble you have been given; a host comes within seconds), where the exits are, what the lights do in an alarm. Red light starts your night vision, because the rods in the eye barely respond to red. You smell nothing yet. The air here is deliberately neutral, so it works as the "zero" your nose is measured against. *See:* red. *Hear:* muffled traffic from the square, fading. *Do:* seal your phone, take your ration card (a card holding six blank smelling strips).

2. Shelter Night, 14 min. Light drops to about 0.5 lux, enough to make out shapes. Bunks are stacked along the north dwarf wall, and the two machine pits are sunk into the floor. Two scents are diffused at room scale: damp brick and earth, then wet wool. Others are handed to you: tea from an enamel mug (real tea), a bar under a glass dome that smells of carbolic soap, and, as the raid starts, a strip carrying a cordite-and-smoke accord. Every one of these is reconstructed by a perfumer from safe, IFRA-compliant materials, with no real explosive residue and no free phenol. The raid is sound and touch: low thuds through floor transducers, plaster dust (a scent, not real dust), the warden's voice counting heads. *See:* almost nothing. *Hear:* the raid in ambisonic sound, a gramophone, someone singing. *Do:* sit on a bunk, hold the mug, find your neighbour's hand if you want to.

3. Memory, 10 min. Fully dark, apart from the hooded exit signs. Oral-history voices (licensing to be agreed with an archive such as IWM; speculation) talk about what people missed: oranges, Sunday roast, a mother's face powder (iris and violet), a seaside summer before the war. Each memory has a warm brass smelling dome at hand height. You find it by touch, lift the lid, and the scent sits only inside the dome, so the room never mixes. *Smell:* orange, roast, face powder, sea air, coal fire. *Do:* follow a handrail with knurled marks at each dome.

4. Raw, 10 min. In the dark, a single fibre-optic pinpoint wakes above each machine pit. By now your eyes are fully adapted, so a point of light the size of a match head feels like a lamp. In each pit sits one rare raw material in an open sealed vessel: ambergris tincture, oud, orris butter, labdanum, jasmine absolute, and a Romagna note from the Terenzi family's own coast (to be chosen with them). A perfumer's voice tells you what each costs and where it comes from. These are the notes the final fragrance is built from. *Do:* add one of the six to your ration card, on a strip the host dips for you.

5. All-Clear, 6 min. Silence, full dark. Then the all-clear: a steady siren note, softer than the original. Over 90 seconds a warm light falls down the glazed hut-shaft stair enclosure, from deep amber to white, like dawn coming down a well. As it reaches the floor, a single burst of dry-air diffusion releases a Tiziana Terenzi extrait across the room. Your pouch unlocks on the base under the shaft. The first photograph most people take is of the light in the shaft. *Smell:* the dawn fragrance (a rotating Terenzi extrait; at launch possibly a London edition, subject to Terenzi).

6. Terenzi Boutique, 10+ min (open-ended). A long, lit gallery along the north side, warm brass and black glass, with the full range on testers and dummy flacons only (HSG51). Your ration card becomes your shopping list: the host smells your six strips with you and points to the fragrances built on them. Discovery sets, candles (never lit), and a London-only "Blackout" discovery box sit by the stair foot. Exit is up the rebuilt hut stair or the platform lift, into the square.

7. Night Bar and bespoke (evening and by appointment). The south wing is a small counter for bespoke consultations by day and the bar for the late format at night. It is never part of the dark route.

The signature moment

The all-clear. Sixty minutes after giving up your phone and most of your sight, you stand under the hut shaft in total dark. The siren sounds, dawn falls down the stair, the room fills with a Terenzi fragrance, and your phone wakes in your hand. The post is the shot straight up the shaft into the light, and then the photo taken outside at the hut doors, blinking in the square. It works because everyone gets the same picture and it cannot be taken any other way.

Making it super cool

1. **Light-locks, not doors.** Each room joins the next through offset openings and a short serpentine baffle, lined with heavy blackout curtains on magnetic tracks. The plan alone keeps light from bleeding between rooms, and the curtains retract automatically on fire alarm.
2. **Dark-adaptation choreography.** A red-light briefing, then 0.5 lux, then darkness lit only by hooded exit signs, then pinpoints. By room 4 your eyes are adapted enough that a fibre-optic point reads as a lamp, so very little light goes a long way.
3. **Scent that never mixes.** Dry-air, presence-triggered micro-diffusion (Scentys or Olfacom type), at most two room-scale atmospheres per room and six to eight scents in total, with everything else in closed domes or on strips. Each room is kept slightly negative to the next, with carbon-filtered extract and a 6-minute fresh-air purge between groups.
4. **The ration card.** A buff card, printed like a 1940s ration book, with six slots for smelling strips the visitor fills on the way. It is the souvenir, the boutique's shopping list, and the follow-up email ("your six notes").
5. **Sound through the body.** Ambisonic speakers for the raid and the voices, plus floor transducers kept to safe, gentle levels. The real rumble of trains far below is folded into the soundtrack rather than fought, with acoustic lining for the rest.
6. **Temperature and air as scenery.** Room 2 runs cool and slightly damp to the touch (16 °C). Room 5 warms by about 4 °C as dawn arrives, with a gentle air movement down the shaft, so the all-clear is felt on the skin as well.
7. **Infrared hosting.** Hosts wear infrared night-vision monoculars and the control room watches IR CCTV, so staff see the dark clearly even when visitors cannot. A visitor who raises the glow-pebble is met in seconds and led out along the lit escape route.
8. **The heritage is the set.** The substation's own plinths, pits, dwarf walls, chain-hoist runway beam and porcelain cable cleats carry the bunks, domes and raw materials. Nothing hides them. A small "as found" panel stays behind glass in room 2.

Above ground

- **Arrival at the hatch.** Timed tickets only. A text arrives 10 minutes before your slot ("Your warden is at the west hatch"). One host waits at the rebuilt steel hatch inside the west railings, takes 12 names and leads you down. There is no kiosk, no queue line and no signage on the lawn beyond a small plate on the railings. If you are early, you sit on the existing garden benches like anyone else.
- **Exit through the hut.** Groups come up through the hut's south doors in twos and threes over a few minutes, so there is never a crowd at the hut. The hut stays a bare protected stair head (ADB 3.38), with no shop and no ticket desk in it, and its exterior is unchanged.
- **Step-free.** Wheelchair users and anyone who cannot use the stair arrive at the hut and go down in the platform lift (Scenario B), are met by a host and taken along the lit route to room 1 before their group, then follow the same visit. Every floor change on the route is ramped.
- **Garden etiquette.** No amplified sound above ground, no costumes outside, no gatherings at the hatch. Evening formats run after the garden closes only if Westminster agrees a managed-access arrangement for the west gate and the hut path (speculation; this is a negotiation, not a given). The Dawn format (below) uses the garden at sunrise on the same condition.

Formats & money

Ticket ladder (all estimates, incl. VAT):

FORMAT	WHEN	GROUP	PRICE
BLACKOUT (standard)	Tue–Sun, 10:00–19:00, every 20 min	12	£38 off-peak, £44 weekend; concession £30; age 10+
Relaxed BLACKOUT	Weekday mornings, monthly	8	£30 (more light, longer rooms, no raid sound)
NIGHT RAID (late)	Thu–Sat 20:00–23:00, 3 slots	12	£75: longer raid with live voice or cello, one paired drink at the Night Bar (licence needed)
DAWN ALL-CLEAR	Once a month around sunrise, 2 groups	12	£95: the finale is timed to real sunrise and you climb out into an empty square
Private buy-out	Evenings	up to 36	£4,000–£6,000
Bespoke consultation	By appointment	1–2	from £750 (Floris benchmark), full bespoke via Terenzi

Capacity per slot: 12 visitors; about 3 slots underground at once; up to 60 people below ground in total, staff included. At 27 day slots a day, that is about 324 places a day and about 100,000 a year at 310 days.

Terenzi boutique role. The boutique is the profit engine. Terenzi runs it (no monobrand Terenzi store exists in London; it opened Rome in 2025 and Milan in 2026). The ticket includes a £10 credit against a full-size purchase, redeemable the same day. Assume 25% conversion at about £160 average transaction (estimate, as in the earlier research).

Non-obvious revenue line: licensing the Shelter Accords. The reconstructed 1940s scents (brick, wool, tea, carbolic, cordite-smoke, face powder, wartime orange) become a licensed library: scent kits for museums, schools and film or theatre productions, and "reminiscence boxes" for dementia-care providers, where smell is used to prompt memory. It also gives the museum a public-benefit story Westminster can point to.

Rough annual revenue (net of VAT and fees; estimate):

STREAM	MID CASE
BLACKOUT tickets: ~60k visitors at 60% occupancy, ~£30 net	£1.80m
NIGHT RAID: ~3,500 a year at ~£58 net	£0.20m
DAWN, Relaxed: small volumes	£0.03m
Private buy-outs: ~60 a year at ~£4k	£0.24m
Boutique: 25% × £160, net of VAT, after the £10 credit	£0.55m (operator margin depends on the deal with Terenzi)
Shelter Accords licensing and kits	£0.05–0.10m
Total	**about £2.9m mid (estimate; range £1.6m at 35% occupancy to £3.8m at 80%)**

This is higher than the earlier plan's £2.0m mid case, because three groups of 12 move through in parallel instead of one hosted group. It is also more exposed to occupancy, and 60,000 a year is above Hidden London's 48,630 across all its sites. Treat the top end with caution.

Fit with the constraints

- **Fire, darkness and escape (the honest part).** Darkness is legal only if it is designed with building control and the fire engineer from the start. Precedents exist: cinemas and theatres run in near-dark with maintained exit signs, and dark-exhibition formats such as Dialogue in the Dark and dining-in-the-dark restaurants have operated in many cities (precedent to check, not verified here). The design rests on these points:
    - Two protected escape stairs, the rebuilt west stair and the rebuilt hut stair, both at least 1000 mm (Scenario B), with escape in two directions from every room and a cap of 60 people below ground, staff included.
    - Exit signs stay lit at all times (they cannot be switched off). They are fitted in shallow hoods that keep them fully visible along the escape route but stop them washing the room.
    - Escape-route lighting is designed to BS 5266. On any fire alarm or mains failure, the show system is overridden and every room goes to full light within a second (fail to light). The blackout curtains retract on the same signal, and the voice alarm takes over the soundtrack.
    - Low-level photoluminescent wayfinding strips and a continuous handrail run along the route.
    - Sprinklers plus mechanical smoke extract (ADB Section 18), as in the earlier plan. All curtains and linings are to a fire classification agreed with building control.
    - No flame anywhere. Perfume stock is held in a 50 L flammables cabinet in the store, with testers and dummy flacons on display, and the raw materials in room 4 in sealed vessels with tiny volumes.
    - Hosts carry IR monoculars, hold a live headcount by group (lanyard tag or counted at each light-lock), and rehearse evacuation in the dark.
- **Heritage.** All fit-out is free-standing and reversible. Plinths, pits, dwarf walls, the runway beam and the porcelain cleats stay in view. The hut's exterior is unchanged; its stair is rebuilt inside under listed building consent. The hatch is rebuilt within its existing footprint.
- **HVAC.** Four separately zoned scent rooms, each slightly negative, with carbon-filtered extract and a timed purge, plus a separate supply to the boutique. Plant sits in the north-west corner (sprinkler tank, pumps, AHU, smoke-extract fans). Where the intake and exhaust surface is unresolved, as for every variant. The likeliest route is within the rebuilt west-stair and hatch footprint (speculation; this needs the M&E engineer and the 1931 Act consent).
- **Accessibility.** Darkness is a leveller for blind and partially sighted visitors, who can use the route on equal terms, and that should be said in the marketing. Wheelchair access depends on the platform lift in the hut shaft, which in turn needs the second stair and, under London Plan D5, probably an evacuation-capable lift. The dwarf walls and pits are bridged by ramps on the route. People with anxiety, claustrophobia or a fear of the dark get the Relaxed format, a host on call, and a lit way out from any room. No strobes or flashing light anywhere (photosensitive epilepsy).

Risks

- **Building control or the fire service may refuse near-dark with 60 people underground.** Fallback: a "dusk" level of about 1–2 lux throughout, which keeps most of the effect but loses the full-dark rooms 3 and 5.
- **Smell carry-over and damp.** Porous brick and an all-year damp load could blur the scents and ruin precise rooms. Sealing, dehumidification and extract may cost more than budgeted, and they should be tested on a mock-up room first.
- **Novelty decay and dependence on one partner.** A dark show sells hard in year one and then needs new reasons to return (seasonal raw materials, new Night Raid scripts). If Terenzi steps back, the boutique, which carries the economics, goes with them.

Prepared by Mia for Alessandro Ticchi, 13/10/2026. Dimensions are estimates from photographs and 2015 press reports. Nothing here has been measured. Site photos: 28DaysLater, Forever Changes, Subterranea Britannica, Evening Standard (2015). Revenue figures are rough estimates for discussion.